

World in Brief: Iran's demands threaten to derail Hormuz reopening; Todd Blanche confirmed as attorney-general



Photograph: Anadolu via Getty Images

Iran issued a sweeping set of demands that it said **America** must meet before it will reopen the **Strait of Hormuz**. The list includes lifting America's naval blockade and sanctions on Iran, as well as the payment of reparations and the withdrawal of American forces from around the country. Iran had been [negotiating](#) with Oman over management of the strait. Its new demands have dimmed hopes that the flow of traffic would resume soon.

America's Senate confirmed **Todd Blanche**—Donald Trump's former personal lawyer—as attorney-general. Mr Blanche sparked outrage for agreeing to create a [\\$1.8bn fund](#) to compensate political allies of Mr Trump over alleged government “lawfare”. Sceptical Republicans were won over only when he formally scrapped it. Two Republicans—Susan Collins of Maine and Lisa Murkowski of Alaska—still voted against him.

The Senate also passed a bill to fund federal agencies until December 11th. America will now be spared the prospect of a **government shutdown** in September, five weeks before the midterm elections. Democrats got behind the bill after they secured a provision barring the transfer of federal funds to the Border Patrol

agency. A government shutdown last October [lasted](#) 43 days, the longest in America's history.

Spain said it would impose border controls on visitors from **Italy**. The temporary measure comes in retaliation for Italy imposing its own restrictions on those entering from Spain following an influx of 72,000 migrants to Ceuta, a north African Spanish exclave. (Most of the people subsequently [returned to Morocco](#).) The two ^{EU} countries, which do not share a land border, normally allow visa-free travel between them.

Berkshire Hathaway's chief executive, Greg Abel, spent a net \$19.8bn on stocks during the second quarter, ending a three-year selling streak by his predecessor, [Warren Buffett](#), that signalled caution over elevated market valuations. The investments include a \$10bn stake in Alphabet. He also bought back \$4.5bn of Berkshire Hathaway's own stock. Quarterly profits from the firm's core businesses rose 16% year over year to around \$13bn.

Volodymyr Zelensky, Ukraine's president, arrived in Belgrade for his first official visit to **Serbia**. The Balkan country has distanced itself from the Kremlin since Russia's [invasion](#) of Ukraine in 2022. Although it refuses to sign up for sanctions against Russia, on which it depends for natural gas, it has scaled down trade with the country and its armed forces have replaced Soviet-era equipment with Western gear.

Audience members at the Edinburgh Fringe praised **Amanda Knox's** controversial comedy show, "Cartwheel", as "powerful" and "respectful" following its opening on Friday. Ms Knox, who was falsely imprisoned in 2007 for the murder of Meredith Kercher, performed despite public backlash. A petition with over 30,000 signatures demanded the show's cancellation. Kercher's family also called for it to be pulled, claiming it trivialised violence against women. Ms Knox was acquitted in 2015.

Word of the week: *haigui*, or sea turtles in Chinese, describing those who come back to China after their studies abroad. Last year the proportion of returnees was 94% of outbound students, [an all-time high](#).

Have you been following the headlines? Test your knowledge of the news with [our weekly quiz](#).

South-East Asia gets hazy



Photograph: Reuters

Singaporeans will look to the skies on Sunday when their country celebrates its National Day with a grand fireworks display. But they may struggle to see clearly. Earlier this week South-East Asia's weather forecaster raised its haze alert to the second-highest level after reports of fires on peatlands and plantations in the Indonesian territories of Kalimantan and Sumatra, which often cause smoke to drift across the region.

Such blazes have recently become more common during the dry season, which runs from June to October. This year meteorologists expect a strong [El Niño](#) to make conditions worse. The weather pattern helped fuel one of South-East Asia's worst hazes on record in 2015. The resulting air pollution is estimated to have caused more than 100,000 excess deaths. It also prompted soul-searching and a flurry of policy measures, from tougher enforcement of crop-burning to closer regional co-operation. In the coming weeks, those measures may face trial by fire.

Edinburgh's exuberant, exorbitant Fringe



Photograph: Getty Images

The world's largest arts festival returns with gusto this weekend. Edinburgh is plastered with posters promoting the Fringe's 4,200 shows, more than ever before. In 2025 2.6m tickets were sold during the month-long jamboree. And this year's eclectic lineup promises to pull in the punters. Visitors can watch theatre in a sauna, stand-up comedy by Amanda Knox (who was convicted, then acquitted, of murdering a student in 2007) or a musical about a Nebraskan sect that wears butt plugs.

But Edinburgh's landlords will have the last laugh. The price of accommodation during August has rocketed by 300% over the past six years. The city has introduced a 5% tourist tax on overnight stays; performers are not exempt. Meanwhile, a cost-of-staging crisis means many will struggle to break even. The likes of Alan Rickman, Stephen Fry and Phoebe Waller-Bridge all credit the Fringe for launching their careers. For performers, though, this catalyst does not come cheap.

Can the Patriot Games excite Americans?



Photograph: freedom250.org

Donald Trump's events celebrating America's 250th birthday have so far been less than spectacular. [A cage fight on the White House lawn](#) in June, which one organiser promised would attract "Super Bowl-type numbers", was broadcast only on Paramount+. (Over 100m people watch the Super Bowl; fewer than that subscribe to the streaming service.) Even MAGA diehards deemed the "Great American State Fair", which was held in Washington, DC, amid scorching temperatures, not worth the risk of heat stroke. So organisers will be hoping that the Patriot Games, which begin on Sunday in Ohio, prove more popular.

The event is billed as a "national athletic competition celebrating the character, determination, and excellence that define the American spirit". Some 120 teenage boys and girls, representing American states, territories and tribal nations, will compete for a shared \$250,000 scholarship prize. In reality, the competition will probably resemble a gym class. Over three days the contenders will play kickball, dodgeball and other games. Wholesome, but not exactly a recipe for ratings success.

Weekend profile: Mohammed VI, Morocco's distracted king



Photograph: Getty Images

Nothing was allowed to interrupt Throne Day on July 30th, an annual ritual in which Morocco's elite swear allegiance to the king. Not even the deaths of more than 140 migrants who were crushed as 72,000 people surged towards [the Spanish exclave of Ceuta](#). The security chiefs who should have dispatched reinforcements were just 16 miles away, attending the ceremonies at the royal palace in M'diq. Too busy bowing and hand-kissing to answer their phones, they left border posts all but abandoned. Officers who had spent months keeping would-be migrants at bay had been redeployed to guard the festivities. Only after the ceremony ended, five hours later, were they sent back. As images of desperate Moroccans flashed around the world, state television remained transfixed by the pageantry of the elite. For the *makhzen*, as Morocco's ruling establishment is known, protocol trumps all.

Mohammed VI once promised to be a different kind of ruler. When he succeeded his father, Hassan II, in 1999, he seemed like a breath of fresh air. He toured undeveloped and sometimes unruly areas his father had shunned, earning the moniker "the king of the poor". He dismissed his father's ruthless enforcers, released political prisoners and modernised the country with motorways and high-speed rail. He married—then, to high society's astonishment, divorced—a commoner; swapped suits for T-shirts; went jet-skiing;

and spent long holidays in Paris and Gabon with kickboxers, nightclub owners and comedians.

Over time, however, the *makhzen* reasserted itself. As Mohammed VI's health declined, the state-run media exposed the king's kickboxer friends as gangsters and [drove them from public view](#). Increasingly the *makhzen* looked to his more disciplined and sterner son, Crown Prince Hassan, for leadership; in May he was appointed co-ordinator of the armed forces. The palace appointed an Islamist prime minister to mollify the Arab Spring protests in 2011, but replaced him in 2017 and later backed the elevation of favoured oligarchs to the post. Critics were locked up on trumped-up sex-crime charges. Too frail to resist, the king has acquiesced. When Gen Z-led protests erupted last year, the response was water cannon and jail terms for some 1,400 young Moroccans. Like his father before him, Mohammed VI has come to embody a monarchy in which ceremony takes precedence. In the wake of Ceuta, he announced that he had named a \$1bn highway in the disputed territory of the Western Sahara, on the opposite end of the country, after Donald Trump (who blamed the tragedy on Spain's socialist government). When disasters strike, the monarch is otherwise engaged.

Mini crossword

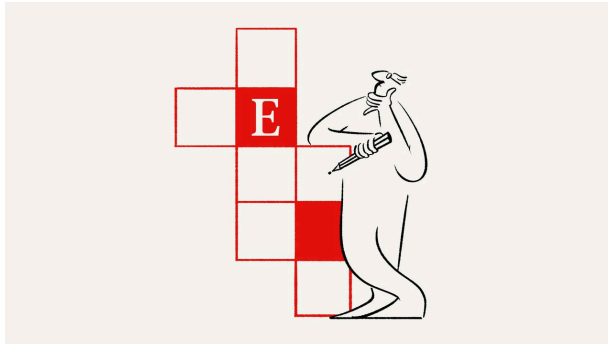


Illustration: The Economist

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Animal eats Ron's first cut of chicken (6)

2 across - Assassin hiding in bamboo thicket (5)

3 across - Cowardly shout. That hurts! (6)

1 down - Fuzzy busy bee is trapped inside fruit (9)

Straight clues

1 across - Robin's is orange actually, not red (6)

2 across - Compartment; small office (5)

3 across - Coldplay's first global hit (6)

1 down - Superfood (9)

*Better to die on your feet than live
on your knees!*

Emiliano Zapata